

SOP-LV-026 — Working at Heights & Fall Protection

Fall Arrest, Fall Restraint & Anchor Point Requirements for Elevated Work

SOP NUMBER	SOP-LV-026
TITLE	Working at Heights & Fall Protection
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APPLIES TO	All Apex field technicians — Ontario & Manitoba
CATEGORY	Ladder & Fall Safety

1. Purpose

This procedure establishes the minimum requirements for protecting Apex technicians from fall hazards when work cannot be performed safely from the ground, a step ladder, or a properly guarded platform. It covers fall restraint and fall arrest systems, anchor point selection, and pre-use inspection of personal fall protection equipment.

2. Scope

This SOP applies to all Apex low-voltage, structured cabling, and security technicians performing work at height on commercial, institutional, and residential jobsites in Ontario and Manitoba, including work from mezzanines, catwalks, open floor edges, roof access points, and any elevated surface not itself covered by SOP-LV-009 (Ladder Safety) or by permanent guardrails. It does not replace a site-specific fall protection plan required by a general contractor or property owner — where a site plan exists, the more restrictive requirement applies.

3. Definitions

- Fall Restraint System — a system that physically prevents a worker from reaching a fall hazard (e.g., a lanyard sized so the worker cannot get within 2m / 6.5ft of an unprotected edge).
- Fall Arrest System — a full-body harness, connecting device (lanyard or self-retracting lifeline), and anchor point rated to stop a fall in progress and limit arrest forces to a survivable level.
- Anchor Point — a secure point of attachment for a fall protection system, capable of supporting the loads specified in Section 6.
- Competent Worker — a worker who has completed Working at Heights training recognized by Ontario's Ministry of Labour, Immigration, Training and Skills Development (or the Manitoba equivalent) and is familiar with the hazards of the specific task.
- Fall Clearance — the total vertical distance required below an anchor point to arrest a fall before the worker strikes a lower level or object.

4. When Fall Protection Is Required

In Ontario, O. Reg. 213/91 (Construction Projects) requires fall protection whenever a worker could fall 3 metres (approx. 10 feet) or more, or could fall less than 3 metres onto a hazardous surface (e.g., exposed rebar, machinery, or a surface likely to

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cause injury). Apex applies this threshold as its company-wide minimum on every jobsite regardless of province, and lowers it further whenever site conditions warrant.

- Working within 2m of an unprotected floor, roof, or slab edge.
- Working on or through openings in floors, ceilings, or roofs (e.g., a slab penetration before it is capped).
- Working from a mezzanine, catwalk, or elevated platform without a permanent guardrail.
- Working from an aerial lift per SOP-LV-027 (Aerial Lift / Scissor Lift Safety).
- Any elevated task the site's own fall protection plan identifies as requiring it, even if below the thresholds above.

5. Pre-Use Equipment Inspection

Before every use, inspect the full-body harness, lanyard or self-retracting lifeline (SRL), and connecting hardware. Do not use equipment that fails any check below — tag it out of service and report it to your supervisor immediately.

- Webbing free of cuts, fraying, burns, chemical damage, or UV degradation.
- Stitching intact with no pulled or broken threads.
- D-rings and buckles free of cracks, distortion, or corrosion.
- Labels and inspection tags present and legible; equipment with no visible manufacture date, or more than 5 years old, must be reviewed by a supervisor before use.
- SRL retracts and locks smoothly with a firm tug test.
- Connecting hardware gates close and lock fully with no play.

6. Selecting an Anchor Point

Every anchor point must be capable of supporting at least 22.2 kN (5,000 lbf) per attached worker, or be part of an engineered system designed and certified by a professional engineer. Never anchor to:

- Guardrails, handrails, or ductwork not rated for fall arrest loads.
- Conduit, cable tray, or any electrical/mechanical infrastructure.
- Any point not specifically identified as an anchor by the site's fall protection plan or a supervisor.

When in doubt about whether a structural element can serve as an anchor, stop and confirm with your supervisor before connecting — the same stop-and-escalate standard Apex applies to unmarked utilities under SOP-LV-002 and SOP-LV-006. If you're not sure, don't guess.

7. Fall Clearance

Before connecting to an anchor point below the working level, confirm there is enough clearance to arrest a fall before the worker contacts a lower surface. As a general rule, a 6-foot (1.8m) shock-absorbing lanyard requires roughly 18.5 feet (5.6m) of clearance below the anchor point; an SRL requires less. If clearance cannot be confirmed, use a fall restraint configuration instead, or escalate to your supervisor.

8. Donning and Use

- Adjust all straps so the harness sits snugly — a loose harness increases injury risk during a fall.

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- Chest strap positioned mid-chest; leg straps snug but not restrictive.
- Dorsal D-ring centred between the shoulder blades.
- Connect only to an approved anchor point per Section 6.
- Never work alone at height without another person aware of your location and task.

9. Rescue Plan

Fall protection is not complete without a plan to rescue a fallen worker promptly — suspension trauma can become life-threatening within minutes. Before starting work requiring fall arrest, confirm with your supervisor how a suspended worker would be retrieved (self-rescue, site rescue team, or emergency services) and how long that would realistically take. If no rescue plan exists for a site, do not begin fall-arrest work until one is established.

10. Training Requirement

In Ontario, workers on construction projects who may use a fall protection system must complete a Working at Heights training program approved by the Chief Prevention Officer, and refresh it every three years. Apex requires this certification, or the Manitoba equivalent, before any technician performs work covered by this SOP. Supervisors confirm current certification before assigning height work.

11. Prohibited Practices

Never reuse fall-arrest equipment after an actual fall.

Any harness, lanyard, or SRL involved in arresting a fall must be removed from service immediately and tagged, even if it appears undamaged. Internal stress from an arrest is not always visible.

- Never anchor above your own head only when a lower, more direct anchor point is available and clearance allows.
- Never modify, alter, or mix components from different manufacturers within a fall protection system.
- Never work at height in high winds, ice, or other conditions that compromise footing or balance without first consulting your supervisor.

12. Incident and Near-Miss Reporting

Any fall, near-miss, or equipment failure involving fall protection must be reported to your supervisor immediately and documented using the Apex Incident Report process, regardless of whether injury occurred.

13. Regulatory References

- Ontario Occupational Health and Safety Act, R.S.O. 1990, c. O.1
- O. Reg. 213/91 (Construction Projects), sections 26.1–26.5 — Fall Protection
- O. Reg. 297/13 — Working at Heights Training Program Requirements
- Manitoba Workplace Safety and Health Act, C.C.S.M. c. W210
- Manitoba Workplace Safety and Health Regulation, Part 14 — Fall Protection
- CSA Z259.10 — Full Body Harnesses

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- CSA Z259.11 — Energy Absorbers and Lanyards
- CSA Z259.2.2 — Self-Retracting Devices

14. Related Apex Documents

- SOP-LV-009 — Ladder Safety — Commercial & Residential
- SOP-LV-027 — Aerial Lift / Scissor Lift Safety
- SOP-LV-003 — Ontario Jobsite Health & Safety Checklist

15. Revision History

Rev.	Date	Description	Approved By
1.0	Jul 25, 2026	Initial release	P. Cimini

This document is proprietary to Apex and is intended for internal use by Apex technicians and supervisors. Effective date: July 25, 2026.